

A Super MINISTRY OF SECURITY

Chidambaram's plan to build a new counter-terror architecture is ambitious but turf battles await him

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora and Sandeep Unnithan

At around noon each day, the wiry frame of India's National Security Adviser (NSA) M.K. Narayanan can be seen crossing the road that separates the two most important office buildings in the country—North and South Block. Narayanan makes his way to the North Block to attend the daily meeting in the office of Home Minister P. Chidambaram. His walk is symbolic of one of the biggest changes post-26/11 Mumbai attacks, a power shift from the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) and the Cabinet Secretariat in South Block to Chidambaram's Home Ministry. Yet, this is only the beginning of what promises to be the most radical post-Independence changes in the crucial ministry.

At an annual Intelligence Bureau (IB) lecture last month, Chidambaram spelt out his vision for a new forward-looking ministry. It will have a National Counter Terrorism Centre (NCTC), an umbrella organisation headed by an officer from the police or armed forces, which will have the triple responsibility of preventing, investigating and responding to terror attacks. The NCTC will be part of a revamped, more compact and powerful Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA). It could well have a new nomenclature too—ministry of internal security,

homeland security (like in the US) or simply security. As has been recommended by several security experts, Chidambaram wants to hive off divisions in the ministry that have nothing to do with internal security: freedom fighters, Centre-state relations, official language, human rights, census and disaster management. As he put it, the ministry has a division to deal with freedom fighters but not with forensic science.

Modelled on a US agency, the NCTC will prevent terrorist attacks, contain these and respond "by inflicting pain upon the perpetrators" as he says. It will deal with all kinds of terror—be it insurgency in the North-east, Maoist violence in the heartland or by fanatic religious groups. He warns, "Sooner than you think, there may be another crisis like the hijack of IC-814 or another catastrophe like the Mumbai terror attacks. Hence, the time to act is now and I would spell the last word in capitals: NOW." Chidambaram is adamant on having the NCTC in place before the year ends. Nobody in the Government or the security set-up has a problem with the MHA revamp. "It is the home minister's business to decide what he wants to do with his ministry and how he allocates work to his ministers of state," says a senior government official. What Chidambaram



CHIDAMBARAM WITH NARAYANAN

What he PROPOSES

- A National Counter Terrorism Centre (NCTC) is to be set up and become nodal agency for counter-terrorism with investigative, analytical and operations wings.
- Joint Intelligence Committee (JIC), National Technical Research Organisation (NTRO), National Security Guard, Intelligence Bureau (IB) and all related agencies to report to the NCTC head.